

Introduction to the Major Scale: Worksheet

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Below is one octave of the C major scale played on a single string. Playing the major scale on a single string allows us to clearly see the interval pattern of the major scale- W W 1/2 W W W 1/2. On the guitar, a whole step is the span of two frets and a half step is one fret. Try playing this series of intervals starting from any fret on any string and you'll hear that you have played the major scale transposed to different keys.

Musical notation in 4/4 time showing one octave of the C major scale on a single string. Below the staff is a guitar TAB with fret numbers 1, 3, 5, 6, 8, 10, 12, and 13.

Play slowly, up and down, using a single left hand finger, while singing the *note names*.

Musical notation showing the C major scale ascending and descending. Note names are written below the staff: C D E F G A B C C B A G F E D C.

Then sing with *scale degree numbers*.

Musical notation showing the C major scale ascending and descending. Scale degree numbers are written below the staff: 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 1 1 7 6 5 4 3 2 1.

We won't do much with these, but you can try *solfège syllables*, as well:

Musical notation showing the C major scale ascending and descending. Solfège syllables are written below the staff: do re mi fa so la ti do do ti la so fa mi re do.

Ex 1: Notate the fingering of the first 6 notes of the C major scale in first position on the first two strings, using the blank TAB stave below AND a blank fretboard diagram. (You'll have to stretch for the 'A' or 6th degree.)

Musical notation showing the first 6 notes of the C major scale (C, D, E, F, G, A) with fingering numbers 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6. Below the staff is a blank guitar TAB stave.

Ex 2: Explore this segment of the C major scale and figure out how to play such hits as, "Twinkle Twinkle Little Star," "Frere Jacques," and anything else you can find. Sing w/ note names and scale degree numbers.

Here's the C major scale on the single 'A' string. This is one *octave* lower, which means the pitches are vibrating half as fast. We humans hear these as the same notes, so we'll give them the same names.

18

TAB

3 5 7 8 10 12 14 15

Ex. 3: Using the 'A' string version as your guide, figure out the fingering of the C major scale in first position, between the 3rd fret on the 'A' string and the 1st fret on the 'B' string. Notate that in the TAB stave below add add it to your fretboard diagram. Learn to play "Twinkle" and "Frere" in this octave.

20

TAB

Ex.4: Fill in the notes below this on your fretboard diagram.

Scale Patterns/Sequences

Ex. 5: Learn to play the thirds pattern/sequence and notate it in the TAB stave below. You can continue above and below this range, but focus on a small segment at a time, for accuracy. Sing scale degrees and note names.

22

1 3 2 4 3 5 4 6 5 7 6 1 7 2 1

TAB

Ex. 6: Do the same for the descending version of the thirds pattern/sequence.

26

1 6 7 5 6 4 5 3 4 2 3 1 2 7 1

TAB

Ex. 7: And do the same for the tetrachord sequence, which bluegrass players call "backstepping." If you feel it will help, write out the entire 1st position in TAB, but it will probably be enough to just do the first few "cells" of the sequence. As awlways, go slowly, work on a limited range at a time, and sing note names and scale degree numbers.

30

1 2 3 4 2 3 4 5 3 4 5 6 4 5 6 7

T
A
B

34

Ex. 8: The descending version of "backstepping."

1 7 6 5 7 6 5 4 6 5 4 3 5 4 3 2

T
A
B

Traid Arpeggios and Diatonic Triad and 7th Chords

Ex. 9: Here are the first 4 diatonic triads in C major played as arpeggios. Notice that they are essentially two thirds played sequentially. Get these under your fingers, mechanically, and allow the sound to get into your ears. This is the ascending version, 1 3 5. (Notice we've ceased using TAB at this point!)

38

Ex 10: And the descending version:

42

Ex 11: To figure out what you've been playing:

- 1) Write out the triads as chords, by 'stacking' two thirds on top of each other on the staff below.
- 2) Label each root note by writing a capital letter above each note.
- 2) Determine the quality of each third in each chord, by playing the interval on a single string; 4 frets is a major third, 3 frets in a minor 3rd. Take note of how those intervals look, when played cross-string.
- 3) Label the quality of each chord (to not give anything away, I've used the letter "R" as a stand-in for the root of the chord) : M3+m3 = major triad (R); m3+M3 = minor triad (Rm); m3+m3 = diminished triad (R° or Rdim)
- 4) Above each chord symbol, write "functional" symbols, replacing the root name letters with Roman numerals, upper case for major, lower case for minor.

46



Ex 12: Now do the same for 7th chords, by stacking 3 thirds. The qualities and symbols are:

M3+m3+M3 = Major 7th (Rma7); m3+M3+m3 = minor 7th (Rm7); M3+m3+m3 = Dominant 7th (R7)
 m3+m3+M3 = Half diminished 7th (Rø7) or minor 7th, flat 5 (Rmi7(b5))

50

